

TANG DYNASTY

618

Military leader Li Yuan seizes power and declares himself the founder of the new Tang Dynasty. He rules as Emperor Gaozu.

630

Emperor Taizong defeats the Eastern Turks, making China the dominant power in East and Central Asia.

690–705

Empress Wu Zetian comes to power and rules over the short-lived Wu Zhou Dynasty.

751

The Abbasid Caliphate armies defeat the Chinese at the Battle of Talas in Central Asia. This stops China's westward expansion.

907

Weakened by uprisings, the Tang Dynasty is overthrown by a military governor called Zhu Wen, who is later replaced by the Song Dynasty.



▲ THE CIVIL SERVICE

Men wishing to work for the Song Dynasty's government had to take a written literary exam that required knowledge of the writings of Confucius. This meant that entry to the civil service was on merit rather than through family connections.



Early gunpowder was made of saltpeter, sulfur, and charcoal.

▲ INVENTIONS

There were many technological advances during the Song Dynasty. Important inventions included paper money, movable type—which made it possible to mass produce books—and gunpowder. A formula for gunpowder was first recorded in a military book in 1044.

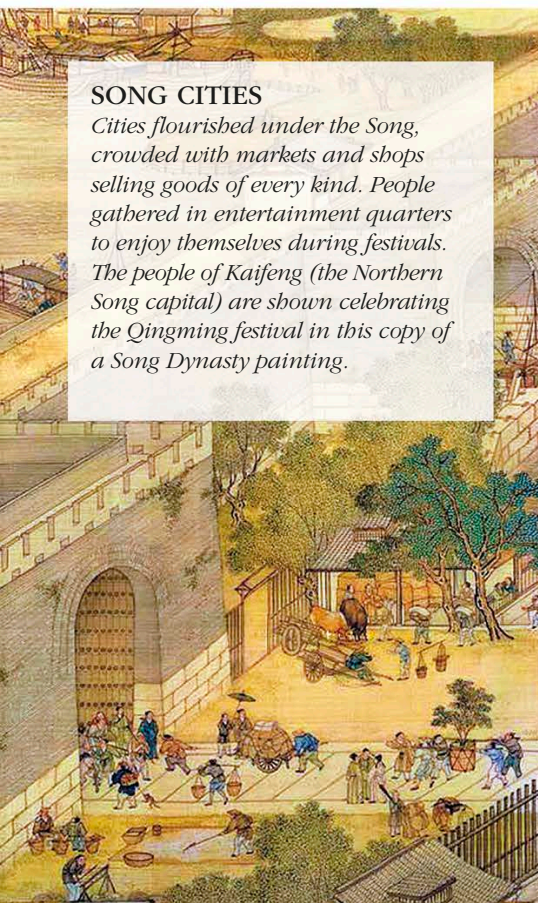
WU ZETIAN

First as the powerful wife of Emperor Gaozong and eventually as sole ruler from 690 to 705, Wu Zetian was the only woman to rule China in her own right. She was an effective leader, introducing reforms to the economy and education system.



SONG CITIES

Cities flourished under the Song, crowded with markets and shops selling goods of every kind. People gathered in entertainment quarters to enjoy themselves during festivals. The people of Kaifeng (the Northern Song capital) are shown celebrating the Qingming festival in this copy of a Song Dynasty painting.



◀ SAILING SHIPS

China was the world's leading maritime power under the Song. Large wooden merchant junks (sailing ships) with up to six masts carried goods across the Indian Ocean to the Middle East. These ships were equipped with detailed navigational charts and magnetic compasses. Under the Song, China also acquired a navy for the first time.

